REAL OR VIRTUAL? REVEALING CULTURAL IDENTITIES THROUGH HETEROTOPIAN CONSTRUCTS IN MUSIQUE-MIXTE

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ABSTRACT

This paper presents a discussion of performative heterotopia within musique-mixte. Heterotopia is proposed as a performance space of connectivity; of interwoven perspectives of experience and practice; and of multiple modes of interaction. Electroacoustic elements of performance are proposed as enablers, as mediators for cross cultural understandings in performance, and the negotiations and relationships created within the space that converge as a shared experience of cultural diversity.

Nicholas Bourriard recounts in his introduction to Michel Foucault's Manet and the object of Painting (2009) that Foucault developed the concept of 'heterotopia' as a way of representing "a constant among all human groups, [which] can be described as 'anti-location'". It consists of an ensemble of "places outside of all places, even though they are at the same time localizable" (Bourriaud, 2009/11). The concept of an ensemble of places expands into heterotopian performance spaces where the performance may articulate diverse relationships and interactions through the integration/juxtaposition of acoustic and electronic elements. Foucault's heterotopias have several main principles: they are a feature of all cultures and societies; they are capable of juxtaposing several spaces within one; they are connected to a slice of time; they assume a system of opening and closing; and, "they have a function in relation to all the space that remains - either to create a space of illusion that exposes every real space, or, to create a space that is other, another real space" (Foucault, 1986). These ideas are here transferred to the music performance space construct and intercultural experience.

The research project, The Imaginary Space: Developing Models for an Emergent Malaysian/Western Electroacoustic Music (Malaysian Government Fundamental Research Grant Scheme 2012-14) (Penny, 2015), aimed to make artistic and cultural connections through the medium of musique-mixte, to experience contemporary and traditional music practices of Malaysia and to examine aspects of cultures and interculturality in a context of new electroacoustic composition and performance. New compositions utilized Western flute, fixed sound and live electronics. It was found that creating a sonic environment through the digital signal processing provided a context for investigation of intercultural parameters and the potential for creative exchange. The capacity of electronic techniques to shift perceptions of sonorities, location, spatial dynamics and characters of the music challenged listener and performer expectations and responses, provoking shifts in understandings and performative identities, and activating new interchanges through a fusion of practices and cultures.

This paper extends the investigation of heterotopian perspectives of this work from the perspective of the flautist. Synthesis and divergences of timbre are investigated through aesthetic and sonic characteristics of serunai, pensol flute, concert flute, Uthmani recitation and DSP – juxtaposing cultures and space. Consideration of dominance and responses of volume include saturation/minimization of electronic sound, micro-sounds and multiplication, and aspects of distance and proximity relate to Foucault's opening and closing of the space. Shifts of cultural identity and new understandings emerging within the temporal in situ performance (Foucault's "slice of time") are described from the inside, the living experience of negotiating distinct musical and cultural behaviours. In addition, the question of whether these exchanges were grounded in the real or virtual is visited – were they illusions or reality?

REFERENCES

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